

FREE GUIDE · FOR JAMAICAN DRIVERS

The Roadside Job Card

What to check, what to say, and what to ask before anyone touches your vehicle — so a small problem stays a small bill.

INSIDE

- The six-point check to run before you call anyone
- How to describe a fault so you are not guessed at
- Eight questions to ask before work starts
- How to read a quote — and what a fair one contains
- Parts: new, aftermarket or used, and what to ask for each
- Six signs the job is going sideways
- A tear-off vehicle card to keep in your glovebox

Before you call anyone

Two minutes here changes the conversation. A mechanic who arrives to a clear description quotes on the fault. One who arrives to “it just stopped” quotes on the risk.

- ☐ **Get off the carriageway first.** Hazards on, wheels turned away from traffic, triangle out if you have one. Nothing below matters more than this.
- ☐ **Note the warning lights** that are actually lit, and whether they came on before or after the trouble started. Photograph the cluster.
- ☐ **Check the obvious three:** fuel gauge, temperature gauge, and whether the battery light is on. A surprising share of call-outs end here.
- ☐ **Look under the vehicle** for anything dripping, and note the colour — clear, brown, red, green or black tells a mechanic different things.
- ☐ **Listen once more.** Try the ignition and pay attention: silence, a single click, rapid clicking and a slow crank are four different faults.
- ☐ **Note where you are** in a way someone else can find: a landmark and a direction of travel beats a road name.

How to describe the fault

You do not need the technical word. You need the *when*. Fill in these four and you have told a mechanic more than most callers do.

SAY THIS	BECAUSE IT SEPARATES
When it happens cold start, after 20 minutes, only over bumps, only braking	A fault that appears only when hot is a different search from one that appears only when cold.
What it does whines, knocks, grinds, shudders, hesitates, pulls left	Rotating noises, impact noises and vibration point at different systems.
What changes it goes away above 40, worse in reverse, stops when I brake	Tells the mechanic which part is loaded when the noise appears.
What happened before drove through water, hit a pothole, just had work done	Recent history is the single most useful thing you can offer, and the most often left out.

Record it. A ten-second voice note of the noise, taken while it is happening, is worth more than any description. Send it with the job.

Eight questions to ask

- 01 **What do you think it is, and how confident are you?** A straight answer distinguishes a diagnosis from a guess.
- 02 **Is there a diagnostic charge, and does it come off the repair?** Agree this before anyone opens anything.
- 03 **What is the total — parts and labour separately?** One lump number cannot be checked or compared.
- 04 **Are the parts new, aftermarket or used?** All three are legitimate. Not being told which is not.
- 05 **What happens if you open it and find more?** Ask them to stop and call you at an agreed figure rather than continue.
- 06 **How long, and can I collect the old parts?** Asking for the old parts back is normal and costs nothing.
- 07 **Is there a warranty on the work, and for how long?** Get it in writing, even a WhatsApp message.
- 08 **Can you put that in a message before you start?** A written quote is the whole of your protection.

Reading a quote

A quote you can check contains:

- ☐ Each part named, with its condition
- ☐ Labour shown separately, with hours
- ☐ Any diagnostic or call-out fee
- ☐ What is *not* included
- ☐ A date, and how long the price holds

Parts — ask this for each:

TYPE	ASK
New / OEM	Is it the maker's part or the maker's supplier's?
Aftermarket	Which brand, and what warranty comes with it?
Used	What is it off, and is it tested or sold as seen?

Six signs the job is going sideways

- ☐ The price moves and nobody called you before it moved.
- ☐ You are told the whole assembly must go, with no explanation of which part failed.

- ☐ Nothing is in writing, and requests to put it in writing are deflected.
- ☐ The old parts cannot be produced and no reason is offered.
- ☐ New faults appear immediately after a repair to an unrelated system.
- ☐ You are pressed to decide now, on the spot, without a second opinion.

One of these is a question. Three is a second opinion. You are entitled to stop, pay for the diagnostic you agreed to, and take the vehicle elsewhere.

Your vehicle card

Fill this in once and photograph it. When something goes wrong, you can send it in one message instead of hunting for a logbook at the roadside.

MAKE & MODEL _____	YEAR _____
ENGINE / FUEL _____	PLATE _____
VIN / CHASSIS _____	
TYRE SIZE _____	BATTERY SIZE _____
LAST SERVICE – DATE / MILEAGE _____	
INSURER & POLICY NO. _____	
PARISH _____	USUAL MECHANIC / GARAGE _____

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